situation in Kashmir, Rao's departure, the Taliban's rise, and Najibullah's murder proved major setbacks to their advocacy.

Conciliators respond to the Taliban

There was little ideological parity between mainstream Indian political parties and the Taliban. One of the few Indian politico-religious figures that supported the Taliban regime in Kabul was Syed Ahmed Bukhari, the Shahi Imam of Delhi's Jama Masjid (he would later also support the 9/11 attacks). What the conciliators wanted was simply to engage with the Taliban, at least politically and covertly even if diplomatic recognition was out of the question.[120] The goal of such engagement was to understand the internal dynamics of the regime better and assess whether a workable (short of granting them official recognition) relationship could be established. They saw reason in Pakistan's Afghanistan policy and concurred that a non-combative stance in Afghanistan would allow constructive engagement with Islamabad. However, such conciliation required India's continuous diplomatic presence in Kabul despite the civil war. Shutting its embassy in September 1996 reduced India's scope to explore and understand the Taliban movement on its own merit. Curiously, India's decision to close its Kabul embassy in 1996 is often treated as a definitive marker of its aversion towards the Taliban. Such was not the case. Still working on a conciliatory principle, New Delhi had ordered its diplomats to keep working in Kabul till it became impossible to continue working. India was the last country to shut its embassy as the Taliban approached the capital and remaining Indian diplomats escaped with bags full of cash (to bribe warlords on the way) using a circuitous route to reach the Bagram airport from where they took a flight to India. Moreover, this was not the first time New Delhi shut its mission in Kabul. Every time fighting broke out in and around Kabul (after Najibullah's fall), most countries including India would close their embassies and remove diplomatic representatives. In fact, this was the fourth closure of India's Kabul mission between 1992 and 1996.

The Indian embassy was first targeted in June 1992 (and remained shut until September 1992) by some Mujahideen elements after the Peshawar Accord was signed.[121] At the same time, about 1,800 Hindu and Sikh Afghan nationals